WOMEN'S VOICES IN TIME OF CRISIS: SOME FEMINIST REACTIONS TO ANTISEMITISM

Before specifically addressing women's roles and attitudes vis-à-vis current Jewish issues, it is necessary to review some characteristics of the women's movements of the 1970s. This includes the concept of solidarity between women (sisterhood), and especially their political engagement. We must remember that women, representing diverse ethnic, national, and religious groups, are not governed by bonds of loyalty and faithfulness to the female gender in general. The concept of "sisterhood" or solidarity with "the community of women" is a recent phenomenon that emerged in the 1970s: it did not take long for its limits to become evident.[18]

Although the sense of shared values and concerns can certainly cross national, cultural, and religious lines, it can also be in tension or conflict with ethnic, religious, political, or familial loyalties. While some Jews seem to have an unconditional sense of solidarity with fellow Jews, this can be met with indifference and even hostility. Currently, the subject of Israel and its policies is a source of tension; sometimes being Jewish makes it easier to vocalize criticism of Israel than for non-Jews.

While we cannot point to any typical "feminist" position regarding the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, it must be noted that is a wide gap exists between legitimate criticism of Israel's policies and calling its very being into question. It may be argued that most feminist activists in peace movements in both Israel and elsewhere abide by a "feminist ethics" of non-violence. The radicalism and anti-Zionism of some can also be explained by the early links between most western feminists and far left revolutionary movements traditionally anti-Israel and pro-Palestinian in all situations (since the 1960s). that are today associated with Islamic groups. Among leftist feminists we can also find a fair and balanced reflection on the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, and a sincere concern about the world-wide increase in antisemitic acts.

American progressive intellectual circles have for some time taken a one-sided anti-Zionist stance. Notably, since 2001, the University of California at Santa Cruz has adopted this officially, as reflected in campus events and course titles, especially in the Feminist Studies Department. It would be out of the question to offer an alternative view on Israel.[19] Judith Butler, a professor of comparative literature at the University of California at Berkeley, is noted for tying anti-Zionism to gender studies. Butler uses her huge influence in feminist and queer theories to spread her positions, which are not just hostile to Israel's policies but to the very foundations of Zionism. She fully supports the BDS movement which calls for a boycott of Israeli products, refuses any academic invitations from Israel, calls for the Jewish

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